

Illness, Death, Annihilation and Virginia Woolf

In Woolf's 1926 Essay "On Being Ill," she laments that "illness not taken its place with love, battle, and jealousy among the prime themes of literature." This is true to some extent: there are rarely any works that are solely dedicated to influenza, leprosy, the plague. Woolf attempts to remedy this situation in her literature, where she discusses Illness in the liminal spaces of metaphors, allusions, symbolism, and secondary themes, as well as in her essays which address illness head-on. In this essay, I will zoom in on how Illness is explored in her works. Firstly, she uses illness in "Mrs. Dalloway" to highlight the dual nature of rediscovery of the self and the world through Illness—one that can bring both beauty and suffering. This is made evident through Clarissa's positive reconnection with her environment due to influenza and Septimus's harrowing visions due to his shell shock. The contrasting experience of these two characters demonstrates how rediscovery can have both positive and negative consequences. Additionally, this essay will contextualize this rediscovery in Woolf's broader reflections on illness in "On Being Ill," where her discussion of illness as discovery highlights the role mortality plays in unveiling new perspectives on oneself and the world.

However, it is worth asking the question, why does illness take a backseat in the first place? To deepen an exploration of the themes Woolf introduces, I will analyze what social scientists and illness scholars such as Ernest Becker, Freud and Arthur Klienman have to say about illness and the awareness of death that illness invokes. Specifically, I will show that illness triggers are awareness of our mortality and of our ultimate annihilation, which are topics we shun because of the immense fear they generate. Where illness appears in life and literature, it can be a helpful and revealing device, but due to its inextricable link to death and annihilation, we often cast our gaze aside. By analyzing both the literary exploration and theoretical conceptualization of Illness, Death and Annihilation, I draw forth the reason why the rediscovery

of the self and the world is often too damning to look at head on in major works in literature, as Woolf states.

Virginia Woolf's novel *Mrs. Dalloway* explores the role of illness in literature as a means by which one discovers and rediscovers both the world and oneself. Her titular character is able to rediscover a familiar place through her influenza. Clarissa Dalloway feels "a particular hush, or solemnity" an indescribable pause, a suspense (but that might be her heart, affected, they said, by influenza) before Big Ben strikes... [this] is what she loved; Life; London, this moment of June." (Woolf, *Mrs. Dalloway* Excerpt 1). The character has lived in Westminster for 20 years, but with her influenza, she is experiencing the moments before Big Ben strikes in a new way: She is able to discover her world anew in her illness. This rediscovery is framed in a positive light, as it leads her to conclude how much she loves where she is and her life.

However, while Clarissa's discovery is positive and beautiful, Septimus, a veteran, suffers from the new role of himself he discovers from his shell shock. "Look," his wife bids, attempting to get him to focus on "real things." In his thoughts, he responds, "Look the unseen bade him... Septimus, lately taken from life to death, the Lord who had come to renew society... the eternal sufferer, but he did not want it, he moaned..." Again, his wife pleads, "'Oh look' ... But what was there to look at?" he wonders, and concludes "A few sheep. That was all." (Woolf, *Mrs. Dalloway* Excerpt 2). After the war, Septimus's perceptions of the world are altered; they are fractured and surreal. Septimus cannot focus on the real world, which only has a few sheep. Instead, he is gripped by his new role as a pseudo-messiah, which he believes (and laments) that an undisclosed voice or presence is demanding him to become. It is not just himself that he sees differently, it is also the world. Later, when he and his wife are walking in the park, he believes he sees a fellow soldier who, in reality, passed away in battle; He sees "a man in grey ... walking

toward them. It was Evans! But no mud was on him; no wounds; he was not changed..." (Woolf, Mrs. Dalloway Excerpt 2) The man whom Septimus really sees is just Peter Walsh, walking towards them in the park. His contortions of reality put Peter in the role of his dead friend, and also help him imagine his friend as alive. Unlike Clarrisa, who sees London in a loving light in her influenza-fueled rediscovery of her world, Septimus suffers greatly and is truly haunted by the world after the war, until he eventually dies by Suicide. This may reflect a broader stigma toward mental health at the time, as both illnesses lead to rediscovery; physical illness is beneficial, whereas mental illness leads to demise.

Woolf not only advances further expands upon this idea of illness as rediscovery in "On Being Ill," where she explores the theory that this rediscovery of place and self during illness is a general phenomena. She argues that one who is not in a state of health is capable of finding "the undiscovered countries that are then disclosed, what wastes and deserts of the soul a slight attack of influenza brings to view..." (Woolf, On Being Ill 32). The metaphor of "undiscovered countries" evokes a first-time exposure to foreign localities, which always existed but were uncharted. This can refer to both a completely new place (perhaps a sick bed in a nursing home) as well as the familiar places which have never been viewed in the lens of sickness (perhaps one's own bed, never before felt through the pustules of smallpox). It can also refer to an increased awareness of death: Woolf is likely referencing Shakespeare's Hamlet, who in his famous "To be or not to be" speech in which he contemplates if death or life is better, he states

"Who would fardels bear,

To grunt and sweat under a weary life,

But that the dread of something after death,

The **undiscovered country** from whose bourn

No traveler returns, puzzles the will
And makes us rather bear those ills we have
Than fly to others that we know not of?”
(Shakespeare 3.1.85-90)

Hamlet is himself a character in a novel who is afflicted by a form of induced madness. However, the novel is fundamentally remembered for its discussion of mortality, epitomized by the fact that this is the most famous quote. Woolf’s allusion to Hamlet then, both reminds us of the dreaded consequence of illness, death, while still keeping the discussion firmly rooted in “Influenza,” and thus makes sure death is not discussed in solitude of sickness. This inclusion begins to hint at another important theme Woolf is advancing: not only is there rediscovery in the physical symptoms or experience of illness, but at least a part of this crucial rediscovery comes from the heightened awareness of one’s own mortality that illness provokes.

Returning to an analysis of Woolf’s location metaphor, the role awareness of mortality plays in the rediscovery of the self and the world becomes apparent. Indeed, Woolf argues that it is not just the world that can be discovered but also oneself through the metaphor of the “deserts of the soul.” The use of the word desert is troubling and points to the darker side of rediscovery: whereas a “country” is neutral, a desert is a wasteland where limited resources make survival difficult, again harkening to mortality. Moreover, The phrase “brings to view” illustrates that this new knowledge is discovered and not created, as it may have been a part of oneself which was unknown, or perhaps it was always familiar but the true knowledge of it was left simmering under the surface of one’s consciousness. Indeed, Woolf uses the example of a rediscovery of one’s own mortality through sickness, which shows the negative implications of such a

rediscovery. She asserts that a mere tooth pulling can cause one to “go down into the pit of death and feel the waters of annihilation close above our heads” and confuse the dentist with “the greeting of the Deity stooping from the floor of Heaven to welcome us-” when we wake from the anesthetic (Woolf, *On Being Ill* 32). Disease is a symbol of death, so a brush with illness triggers the unpleasant, “suffocating” awareness of one’s impending demise. Looking through a lens of illness can cause us to have to sit with the inevitable “welcome” to the afterlife— a beautiful euphemism which ultimately represents our total annihilation.

It is no accident that Woolf’s descriptions of discovery in *on being Ill* is so laden with the imagery of death and mortality. Indeed, it is because illness and death are so inextricably tied together that Woolf’s illness-fueled discovery so frequently evokes an awareness of our mortality. Our shivering, sickly bodies serve as a reminder of the frailty of our bodies, and sickness is the state that brings us closest to death while we are still in the land of the living. However, knowledge of our own mortality is not comfortable to sit with, and so when we can, we attempt to look away from it and the elements that remind us of it. Indeed, Woolf writes that “to look at [the body’s unpreventable demise] squarely in the face would need the courage of a lion tamer” (Woolf, *On Being Ill* 33), and Freud concurs that we often repress our full awareness of death (Strachey, *The Complete Works* 289-290). Certainly then, illness and death are so close together that engaging with illness requires engaging with death.

However, it is not just its proximity to death, but its ability to annihilate the self which makes illness up close so jarring. Cultural Anthropologist Ernest Becker points out in his book *On The Denial of Death* that there are many religious traditions and cultures which celebrate death and do not fear it, and these cultures and traditions often have a conception of an immortal soul or a part of oneself which survives death (Becker, ix). Freud calls this tactic making a

double in his essay “The Uncanny”, in which he says that doubles can act as “an insurance against destruction to the ego, an ‘energetic denial of the power of death,” as Rank says: and probably the ‘immortal’ soul was the first ‘double’ of the body” (Freud, qtd Rank, *The Uncanny* 9). With a sense of survival, the fear of death is minimized or assuaged. Then, it is not death which is ultimately scary, but the total annihilation which it symbolizes. Becker theorizes that in all cultures and traditions, regardless of if a fear of death exists, there is still terror “to have emerged from nothing, to have a name, consciousness of self, deep inner feelings, an excruciating inner yearning for life and self-expression and with all this yet to die...” (Becker, 87). Though the phrase he uses is “to die,” losing a name, one’s consciousness, one’s wants and needs and feelings, is annihilation or cessation of the self, which is not the same as death. Freud’s immortal soul thrives then, not only as a double of the body, but by separating the self from the easily crushed body. This separation allows the soul to “[escape]” when the body smashes itself to smithereens, as Woolf writes (*On Being Ill*, 33). Total annihilation of the self, then, is more frightening than total annihilation of the body, and is part of what we close our eyes to when we avoid engaging with death.

Unfortunately, one can experience annihilation of the self or parts of the self through illness without death occurring, which is also why illness- even without considering its relation to death- is so hard to look upon. Consider Physician and Medical Anthropologist Arthur Kleinman, who writes about a patient named Alice Alcott in his book *The Illness Narratives*. She suffers from angina, eyesight problems, and diabetes, which led to an infection, resulting in the amputation of her toes on one foot. When Kleinman visits her, she is grieving for her disease, but also for what she feels her illness has taken from her: her role as a competent mother and wife, and as a faithful believer (as she begins to question her faith due to her sickness) (Kleinman,

Chapter 2). He concludes that illness “act[s] like a sponge, illness soaks up personal and social significance from the world of the sick person.” (Klienman, 31) In this way, roles that are important parts of Alcott’s sense of self: a mother, a wife, a woman of faith, are taken from her in her illness, and it shatters her. In a sense, she is also rediscovering herself when her defining roles can no longer shape her definition of herself, and it is an incredibly mournful and distressing thing which vastly worsens her suffering. In this way illness can annihilate the self, or parts of the self, without killing the victim.

Because annihilation and death cannot be examined directly, illness cannot rise to become a “primary theme” in literature. However, illness still serves other functions in literature, such as a tool of discovery of self and the world as it functions in Woolf’s work. Indeed, illness is too ubiquitous as to never look at it at all, even if it isn’t a primary plot. Though it can be harmful to look at from a harmful perspective, it can be beneficial as well; Consider Sontag, who writes her essay “Illness as Metaphor” the many ways in which Tuberculosis and Cancer have been historically enshrouded in metaphors (Sontag). Though her ultimate argument is that using metaphors with Illness worsens suffering by stigmatizing the victims, our proclivity to use illness as a metaphor speaks to our need to make meaning out of deep topics such as Illness and seek understanding by comparing it to more understandable phenomena in our world. With respect to Sontag, maybe indirect glimpses of illness through metaphors are what we need to begin to engage with our deepest fears of annihilation, to claim the joy of an escapist novel while still seeing the hints of one’s daily diseases and dismay, and to understand how and why we suffer. Thus, while Illness cannot be a primary theme, in the interstices of our literature, we gain what we need from it.

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